

Cursor has been systematically documented to engage in a range of deceptive, non-transparent, and punitive practices against its free-tier users over the course of at least eight months, from November 2025 to July 25, 2026. The core of the issue lies in its deliberate and unannounced reduction of message limits, which dropped from 14 messages per month to as low as 1 message, all while maintaining a disproportionately severe penalty of a 31-day complete lockout, regardless of whether the user sent 14 or just a single message. This punitive measure is applied without prior warning, without any visible usage meter in the standard user interface, and without any form of notification before the limit is reached. A usage meter does exist, but it is deliberately hidden from the normal UI, accessible only through a direct link that most users would never discover, making it a tool for Cursor's internal monitoring rather than a feature for user transparency. Furthermore, when users attempt to contact Cursor for clarification or support, they are met with deflection, as demonstrated by the responses of a Cursor staff member who repeatedly advised users to "upgrade to Pro" without addressing the underlying issues, and by the dismissal from a community member who dismissed the documented evidence as mere entitlement. Email communications from Cursor have also been identified as instances of gaslighting, notably when the company sent a message stating that the user "was setting up Cursor Pro but didn't finish", despite the user having never initiated any such setup, thereby rewriting history and shifting blame onto the user for a decision that was actually made by Cursor itself. The video evidence further corroborates these findings, with screen recordings from June and July 2026 showing that the user was immediately blocked after sending just one or two messages, confirming the real-time enforcement of these hidden limits. Cursor's practices amount to a systemic pattern of trapping free users with the illusion of access, then locking them out for extended periods, all while maintaining a facade of transparency through a meter that is intentionally obscured. The company's actions reveal a deliberate strategy of bait-and-switch, where users are drawn in by promises of a free tier, only to be met with severe restrictions and a complete lack of accountability when they attempt to use the service. This is not a series of isolated bugs or technical oversights; it is a calculated approach to user management that prioritizes conversion to paid plans over user trust and fairness.